

SBA 8(a) Business Development Program

Reference Notes · Source: sba.gov/8a · Last updated March 19, 2026

■ Program Overview

Authorized under **Sections 7(j)(10) and 8(a) of the Small Business Act** (15 U.S.C. §§ 636(j)(10) & 637(a)). Administered by the SBA to provide management, technical, financial, and procurement assistance to socially and economically disadvantaged

■ Eligibility Requirements

Criterion	Requirement
Business size	Must qualify as a small business under SBA size standards
Prior participation	Must NOT have previously participated in the 8(a) program (one-time only per individual)
Ownership	At least 51% owned and controlled by U.S. citizens who are socially and economically disadvantaged
Personal net worth	\$850,000 or less
Adjusted gross income	\$400,000 or less
Total assets	\$6.5 million or less
Character	Must demonstrate good character
Time in business	At least 2 years (demonstrates potential for success)

Exception: Alaska Native Corporations, Indian Tribes, Native Hawaiian Organizations, and Community Development

■ ■ Program Structure — 9-Year Term

Stage	Duration	Focus
Development	Years 1 – 4	Building capacity; training, technical & management assistance
Transitional	Years 5 – 9	Competing independently; reducing reliance on program support

■ Program Benefits

- Compete for **set-aside and sole-source contracts**
- One-on-one support from dedicated **Business Opportunity Specialists** for the full 9-year term
- Access to **SBA Mentor-Protégé program** for mentorship from experienced firms
- Ability to form **joint ventures** with established businesses to increase capacity
- Priority access to **federal surplus property**
- Free training via **SBA's Empower to Grow** program

■ Sole-Source Contract Thresholds

Acquisition Type	Threshold / Rule
Manufacturing (NAICS codes)	Up to \$7 million sole-source
All other acquisitions	Up to \$4.5 million sole-source

Acquisition Type	Threshold / Rule
DoD — entity-owned participants	Formal justification required if contract exceeds \$100 million
All other federal agencies — entity-owned	Agency approval required if contract exceeds \$25 million

■ Key Terms

Participant	A certified small business actively enrolled in the 8(a) program, receiving SBA assistance and eligible for set-aside contracts.
8(a) Contractor	An 8(a)-certified firm that has been awarded a federal contract through the program's sole-source or competitive set-aside mechanisms.
Sole-Source Contract	A contract awarded directly to an 8(a) participant without competition, up to the applicable dollar threshold (\$4.5M general / \$7M manufacturing).
Competitive Threshold	The dollar limit above which 8(a) contracts must be competed among eligible 8(a) firms rather than awarded sole-source.
NAICS Code	North American Industry Classification System code classifying a business's primary industry for size-standard and contracting purposes.
SAM	System for Award Management — mandatory federal registration required before applying for 8(a) certification (sam.gov).

■ How to Apply

Step 1. Identify your primary **NAICS code(s)** using SBA's Table of Size Standards.

Step 2. Register your business in the **System for Award Management (SAM)** at sam.gov.

Step 3. Complete the eligibility questionnaire and **apply via MySBA Certifications** at certifications.sba.gov.

Step 4. SBA reviews the application — once complete, a decision is rendered within **90 days**.

Source: U.S. Small Business Administration — sba.gov/8a · Legal authority: 15 U.S.C. §§ 636(j)(10) & 637(a) · Regulations: 13 C.F.R. Part 124 · Contact: certifications@sba.gov · 866-722-4357